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Ellen Bozman Dies at 83; Spent Record Tenure on County Board

- by SCOTT McCAFFREY, Staff Writer
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Ellen Bozman served on the County Board for a record 24 years, but her role in Arlington civic life lasted twice that long.

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Ellen Bozman, whose nearly six decades of community activism in Arlington was capped by a record 24 years on the County Board, died Jan. 8 at Virginia Hospital Center. She was 83, and had been fighting a recurrence of breast cancer.

As a community activist and, later, elected leader, Bozman's efforts ran the gamut: As a member of the Planning Commission, she helped set the stage for Arlington's effort to develop its Metro corridors, while she also was a tireless advocate of those in need, particularly children.

"Her entire adult life was devoted to the improvement of public life in Arlington," said state Sen. Mary Margaret Whipple, D-31st, who served on the County Board with Bozman.

"Ellen was my mentor: All she really cared about was making Arlington and the region better," Whipple said.

Bozman's efforts in community leadership began in the school-integration battles of the 1950s, and continued in both the planning and social-service arenas through the 1960s and 1970s.

As a politician, few Arlington leaders could match her record: Bozman was a perfect six-for-six in political races, winning County Board terms every four years from 1973 to 1993. In 1997, she opted not to seek re-election.

"She really had a respect for making government work - good, open, transparent government," said County Board Chairman Barbara Favola, whose own involvement in political life began when Bozman appointed her to the Health Center Advisory Commission.

"In her heart, she felt government was a tool to improve the lives of people, a tool for good," Favola said.

Even after nearly a quarter-century on the County Board, Bozman remained active in community life, working on issues that ranged from affordable housing to health care to education.

"Ellen embodied all that is right about Arlington: She was gracious, caring, thoughtful and committed to good, honest government," said County Board Vice Chairman Jay Fisette, who in 1998 succeeded to the seat Bozman had held for nearly a quarter-century.

As news of her passing spread, accolades poured in:

* Bozman was "a jewel in the community," said Betsy Frantz, president of Leadership Arlington, a program Bozman supported and helped guide during its infancy.

* “We owe her tremendous gratitude,” said Wanda Pierce, executive director of the Arlington Community Foundation, another organization that Bozman nurtured throughout its existence, and where she served as president.

* Rich Doud, speaking on behalf of the Arlington Chamber of Commerce, said Bozman “led Arlington with a highly held belief set, strong senses of honor and purpose and graciousness. Her impact on Arlington was unprecedented.”

Bozman was serving on the Planning Commission when she made her first bid for County Board in 1973. In her first five campaigns, Bozman competed not as a Democrat but under the banner of Arlingtonians for a Better County, which while technically nonpartisan was allied with the local Democrats.

The 1973 race had been seen as a showdown between Bozman and incumbent Republican board member Dr. Kenneth Haggerty. Haggerty opted to retire, and Bozman won 51 percent of the vote against former Republican Del. Henry Lampe and independent Sherman Pratt.

She faced opponents in each of her successive runs:

* In 1977, Bozman won 53 percent of the vote against Pratt and Arthur Vogul, both running as independents.

* In 1981, she received 76 percent of the vote against Republican Robert Harrington.

* In 1985, she received 70 percent of the vote against independent Richard Herbst.

* In 1989, she received 65 percent of the vote against Republican Jim Robinson.

* In 1993, running for the lone time as a Democrat, she received 65 percent of the vote against Republican John Barr and independent Michael Ward.

Bozman was tapped for her first of six one-year terms as chairman in 1976. Her ascension marked the first time in nearly 20 years that a woman had chaired the board. She served her final stint as chairman in 1997, her last year in office.

Her 24 years on the board were interrupted once, in 1977, for a three-week period. Having won re-election but not able to take office for a new term until Jan. 1, Bozman resigned from the board in November 1977 after being informed she had technically violated the law by also serving on the Arlington Health Center Commission.

Although she had been appointed to that position by her board colleagues, who presumed the action had been proper, it turned out Bozman was not legally allowed to hold both positions.

After her County Board resignation, her colleagues could have reappointed her to the position. But Republican board members Dorothy Grotos and Walter Frankland refused to go along with the appointment, and her position remained vacant until the new board came into office in January 1978, when Bozman, in effect, succeeded herself.

(As board members wrangled for more than two hours over whether she should be appointed for the interim period, Bozman calmly sat in the audience, knitting. When the proposal was defeated, she sat around for about an hour, then went home . . . chuckling about the incident.)

When Bozman announced she would not seek re-election in 1997, Democrats Jay Fisette and Barbara Favola squared off in a party primary to succeed her.

Fisette won the primary, but Favola made it to the County Board first, as she won a special election to fill the seat of James Hunter III, who had resigned due to ill health.

After retirement, in 1998, Bozman was honored by the General Assembly, which approved a joint resolution lauding her “sterling career of service to the citizens of Arlington.”

In 1986, Bozman was honored as a “Washingtonian of the Year” by Washingtonian magazine. “Without Ellen Bozman, Arlington County would not be as nice a place as it is,” the magazine said.

Bozman received the Elizabeth and David Scull Public Service Award from the Metropolitan Washington Council of Governments in 1983, and was honored with the Jefferson Cup by the Virginia Association of Counties in 1997. In 1998, she received an honorary doctor of humane letters degree from Marymount University.

During her years in civic life, Bozman represented Arlington on a number of regional organizations, including the Northern Virginia Regional Park Authority, Metropolitan Washington Council of Governments, Northern Virginia Transportation Commission, Northern Virginia Planning District Commission and Virginia Association of Counties.

Locally, she held leadership or membership positions through the years with the League of Women Voters, Arlington Symphony, Committee of 100, Veterans Branch YMCA, Alliance for Housing Solutions, Arlington Health and Welfare Council, Arlington Community Foundation, local PTAs and Rock Spring Congregational United Church of Christ. She was a founder of the Arlington Farmers’ Market.

In her last year on the County Board, Bozman established Neighborhood Day, an annual event designed to highlight Arlington’s growing diversity. For most of the past dozen years, she was master of ceremonies at the annual James Hunter III Community Hero Awards, which were held on Neighborhood Day.

Born Ellen McConnell, April 21, 1925, in Springfield, Ill., in 1946 she graduated Phi Beta Kappa from Northwestern University with a degree in political science.

After graduation, she moved to the Washington area. For a while, her roommate was dating a young man named Bill Bozman, and when that romance fizzled, he and she began dating. (She once told the Arlington County Democratic Committee that it was her “great legs” that attracted him.)

The couple married on Dec. 29, 1949, and moved to Arlington less than a year later. They had two sons and a daughter. Ellen Bozman gave up her federal career to raise the children.

In the 1950s, Arlington was a focal point in the battle over segregation in Virginia. The state government was pursuing a policy of “massive resistance” against court-ordered segregation, a policy that was opposed to by the large crop of relatively new arrivals in Arlington. Bozman’s activism began in this era, as she took on leadership efforts with the Arlington League of Women Voters.

In addition to her husband, Bozman is survived by their three children: William (Mac) Bozman of Winchester; Martha Bozman of Arlington, her husband, Blair Reischer, and their children, Rosalind and Peter; and Bruce Bozman of Bristol, Wisc., his wife, Alison, and their children, Shannon and Cameron; and a niece, Susan Geiger, of Arlington.

The family will receive visitors at Rock Spring Congregational United Church of Christ, 5010 Little Falls Rd., on Friday, Jan. 23 from 7:30 to 9 p.m. A memorial service is scheduled for Saturday, Jan. 24 at 3 p.m. at the church.

In lieu of flowers, the family asks that donations be made to the Arlington Community Foundation’s Ellen Bozman Fund or to the Alliance for Housing Solutions.

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